When an object is divided repeatedly, the process of division could not be done beyond a certain stage in a similar way and we end up with a small speck. This small speck was defined as an atom. The word atom in Greek means 'without division or indivisible'. The size of an atom is very very small. For an example, the size of hydrogen atom (simplest among other atoms) is around 10^{-10} m. An American Physicist Richard P. Feynman said that if the size of an atom becomes the size of an apple, then the size of apple becomes the size of the earth as shown in Figure 9.1. Such a small entity is an atom.

In this unit, we first discuss the theoretical models of atom to understand its structure. The Bohr atom model is more successful than J. J. Thomson and Rutherford atom models. It explained many unsolved issues in those days and also gave better understanding of chemistry.

Later, scientists observed that even the atom is not the fundamental entity. It consists of electrons and nucleus. Around 1930, scientists discovered that nucleus is also made of proton and neutron. Further research discovered that even the proton and neutron are made up of fundamental entities known as quarks.

In this context, the remaining part of this unit is written to understand the structure and basic properties of nucleus. Further how the nuclear energy is produced and utilized are discussed.

9.2 ELECTRIC DISCHARGE THROUGH GASES

Gases at normal atmospheric pressure are poor conductors of electricity because they do not have free electrons for conduction. But by special arrangement, one can make a gas to conduct electricity.

A simple and convenient device used to study the conduction of electricity through gases is known as gas discharge tube. The arrangement of discharge tube is shown in Figure 9.2. It consists of a long closed glass tube (of length nearly 50 cm and diameter of 4 cm) inside of which a gas in pure form is filled usually. The small opening in the tube is connected to a high vacuum pump and a low-pressure gauge. This tube is fitted with two metallic plates known as electrodes which are connected to secondary of an induction coil. The electrode connected to positive of secondary is known as anode and the electrode to the negative of the secondary is cathode. The potential of secondary is maintained at about 50 kV.

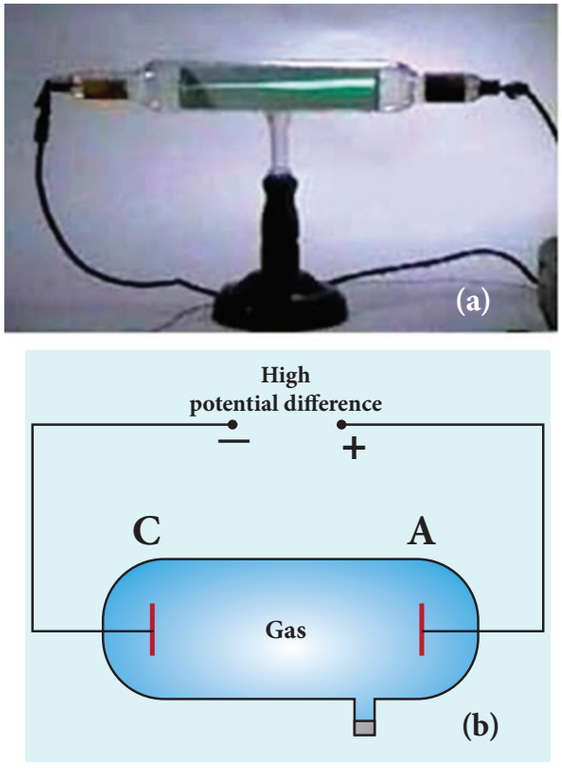


Figure 9.2 Discharge tube (a) real picture (b) schematic diagram

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